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KAYLA BARTKOWSKI Los Angeles Times

WILDLIFE CROSSING ON TRACK

The corridor over the 101 in Agoura Hills is set to open Dec. 2 — unless El Niño intervenes. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Years of red flags in Arcadia mass surrogacy case

Before abuse claims, couple was the subject of scrutiny by local police, child services.

BY JAMES QUEALLY

In 2019, two years before Guojun Xuan and Silvia Zhang began amassing a family of more than 20 surrogate children, Zhang was accused of misdemeanor child abuse after leaving her then-8-year-old daughter in a hot car for hours.

That case — detailed in a recent motion by prosecutors opposing bail for the couple and a spokesperson for the L.A. County Sheriff's Department — could have affected their ability to engage in the surrogacy process, if a surrogacy firm conducted a diligent background check of the aspiring parents, according to two civil attorneys.

But Xuan and Zhang, the attorneys said, were able to sidestep what few safeguards exist in the generally unregulated U.S. surrogacy industry by creating their own firm, Mark Surrogacy Investments. While there are almost no rules governing who can and cannot acquire a child through the surrogacy process — which involves paying women to receive embryo transfers and carry the babies to term — independent firms still conduct due diligence on prospective clients and surrogates, according to Maya Shulman, a Calabasas-based surrogacy lawyer.

By launching their own firm, Xuan and Zhang were able to ensure no one looked into their backgrounds, Shulman said.

"No respectable agency and no respectable attorney would have represented her," Shulman said.

A Sheriff's Department spokesperson said the child left in the car was not seriously injured, and court records show Zhang entered into a diversionary plea agreement with L.A. County prosecutors, the terms of which were completed in 2023, allowing the case to be dismissed. All records in the

[See **Surrogacy,** A7]

TRUMP ENVOY OUSTED AMID SCANDAL

Guilfoyle resigns as ambassador to Greece under pressure, denies influence peddling.

BY KEVIN RECTOR AND ANA CEBALLOS

Kimberly Guilfoyle resigned her post as ambassador to Greece on Tuesday, after being asked to do so by President Trump amid a wave of misconduct allegations she has denied.

Guilfoyle, a former Trump campaign surrogate and onetime fiancee of Donald Trump Jr., faced allegations including an offer to use her influence in Trump's orbit in exchange for payments, according to the Wall Street Journal — adding her to a growing number of Trump administration officials, family members and employees who have been accused of improperly monetizing their ties to the president or his government.

That list includes Trump and his sons, who have been criticized for making billions through investments in industries that are regulated by the administration — including in cryptocurrency and drone interceptors — and for trying to sell early access to Trump's posts on his social media platform. Trump Jr. has also faced criticism for having his lavish Bahamas wedding paid for in part by a Russian oligarch close to President Vladimir Putin.

The business ventures of Jared Kushner, the president's son-in-law and one of the administration's top negotiators in the Middle East, have also raised questions, as Kushner has been tied to Russian oil negotiations amid talks on how to end the war with Ukraine and reportedly tried to raise money for his private firm from governments in the Middle East.

Meanwhile, Commerce Secretary Howard Lutnick and his son Brandon Lutnick, now chair of the financial services firm Cantor Fitzgerald, have been questioned over the firm buying up rights to refunds from Trump's dismantled tariff scheme. Howard Lutnick, who previously served as Cantor Fitzgerald's chairman, championed Trump's tariffs.

In a statement posted to social media, Guilfoyle said she will "forever be grateful" to Trump and Secretary of State Marco Rubio for trusting her to represent the U.S. abroad, remains "unwavering" in her support for them and "worked tirelessly to ad-

[See **Guilfoyle,** A8]

More young couples say 'sign here' before 'I do'

By Grace Kelleher

Prior to saying "I do" in 2022, Roshni Patel and her partner had an important task they wanted to take care of: negotiating and signing a prenuptial agreement. For 28-year-old Patel, a prenup isn't just a contingency plan; it's something a bit closer to self-care.

"It's not about my partner," said Patel, who lives in Silver Lake and works in business operations. "It's about me knowing that I am doing my best to take care of myself, regardless of the situation." Patel is part of a generation approaching marriage — and the legal architecture around it — very differently than their parents did.

Society is in the midst of a zillennial prenup boom. According to a recent Harris Poll with Bloomberg, 53% of engaged or married Gen Zs and millennials have signed a prenup as of this spring. That's a striking increase from 2022, when 39% of engaged or married 18-to-34-year-olds reported having one — and only 15% of engaged or married Americans overall did.

There are practical reasons for the boom. Zillennials, the microgeneration on the cusp between Gen Z and millennials, came of age during the 2008 financial crisis and the COVID-19 pandemic. Many watched their parents' marriages struggle and drew their own conclusions. In the last several decades, women's matriculation rates and early career outcomes have caught up to — and in some cases, outpaced — those of men, thus reshaping the calculus underlying many partnerships.

For some, the

[See **Prenups,** A6]

1st-class treatment for nonprofit boss

Shelter service rented luxury Santa Monica apartment and leased a BMW for its CEO.

BY AUDREY MCGLINCHY

For more than four decades, the 1736 Family Crisis Center has offered care for victims of domestic violence, running shelters and crisis hotlines in L.A. and Orange counties on what today is a $15-million budget.

But the primary residence of the nonprofit's chief executive has been in Hawaii for at least the last 10 years. And for at least part of that time, the organization has paid for a luxury beachside apartment in Santa Monica for her visits to the region, and leased a BMW for her personal use at home on the Big Island, according to nonprofit records reviewed by The Times and a lawyer who fielded employee concerns in 2019.

It's unclear how long the 1736 FCC paid for the $6,500-a-month apartment or if it continues to do so. Board members for the nonprofit, which runs domestic violence shelters in the L.A. area, approved the arrangement in 2018, according to emails. The nonprofit was paying rent the following year, according to a bank transaction. The center's attorney, Kerry Garvis Wright, would not provide details about how long the payments lasted.

In a letter to the Times, Wright said the 1736 FCC rented the apartment for its CEO because it was a more predictable expense compared with one-off hotel stays for her visits to L.A.

Wright also said it offered high-level security for an executive concerned about her safety.

In August, The Times reported the unusually large compensation paid to the nonprofit's chief executive, Carol Adelkoff. According to the organization's latest tax filings, Adelkoff was paid $1.6 million over two years, roughly half of which came from a payout of unused vacation accrued over four

[See **Adelkoff,** A11]



DAVID FOUTS For The Times

VALUEROCK Realty has filed early plans to replace landmark with apartments.

Diner's on shaky ground

Future is in doubt for Googie-style Santa Monica spot

BY CHRISTOPHER REYNOLDS

For decades, the bold, mid-century building at Lincoln and Olympic boulevards in Santa Monica has been the end of the line — the last address on the 2,400-mile westward journey of Route 66. Once home to the Penguin Coffee Shop, today it holds Mel's Drive-In. But now its future is in doubt.

The owners of the property have filed early paperwork to level the structure and replace it with an eight-story apartment building. Preservationists are pushing for a historic designation that might protect it.

The groups appear headed toward a showdown Dec. 14, when the Santa Monica Landmarks Commission will hold a hearing on the site's nomination for protected status by the Santa Monica Conservancy and the Los Angeles Conservancy. The allied conservancies contend that the building is "the most significant representation of its style and period in architecture and design in Santa Monica."

"This isn't about saving a modern restaurant. It's about preserving some really important Googie architecture," said Nina Fresco, vice president of Santa Monica Conservancy. She added that "there's no reason why housing and historic preservation can't be partners."

Irvine-based firm ValueRock Realty bought the half-acre Mel's property for $6.2 million in 2020, and in 2025 began offering the property for sale, asking $26 million through brokers Newmark Pacific.

Soon after learning that

[See **Diner,** A10]

Tupac Shakur's killer is sentenced

Gang leader who supplied gun used in rapper's 1996 slaying gets 40 years to life.

BY RICHARD WINTON

The man who orchestrated the killing of rapper Tupac Shakur, fueling a bicoastal feud that involved gang members and record company executives, has been sentenced to 40 years to life in prison.

While sentencing Duane "Keffe D" Davis on Tuesday, Clark County District Judge Carli Lynn Kierny said: "You don't get to take a man from his family ... and just walk away from it, especially Tupac Shakur. The world never forgot about him and his death, and neither did Las Vegas."

The jury convicted Davis, 63, of murder and use of a deadly weapon for orchestrating the rapper's fatal shooting on Sept. 7, 1996, and sentenced him to consecutive terms of 20 years to life, 40 years to life in total.

During the two-week trial, prosecutors presented evidence that Davis, as his gang's shot caller, arranged Shakur's killing by passing a .40-caliber handgun to fellow members of the Southside Crips-Burris Street gang as they rode in a Cadillac near the Las Vegas Strip. The key evidence included interviews Davis gave authorities, a documentary and his own 2019 memoir detailing the killing.

"I am going to appeal this case for sure," Davis told the judge before his sentencing.

Shakur's killing came during a fraught time in the rap world. Death Row Records, run at the time by Marion "Suge" Knight, was in a cross-country rivalry with Bad Boy Records, run by Sean "Diddy" Combs.

When Shakur was killed, it sparked conspiracy theories about who was involved as well as introspection in the music industry. It also ignited a 10-day gang war in Compton.

For Shakur's family, the effects were personal and devastating.

[See **Shakur,** A8]

Pope has cancer, surgery confirms

Doctors removed the lower lobe of his right lung and await more test results, the Vatican says. **PERSPECTIVES, A2**

A gleaming new Burbank airport

The $1.3-billion terminal is roomier than the two it replaced, featuring upgraded amenities and art. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

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MARIO TOMASSETTI Pool Photo

POPE LEO presides over Mass at St. Peter's Basilica on Thursday.

Final debate in L.A. mayor race

For full coverage of the last debate between Karen Bass and challenger Nithya Raman, visit *latimes.com*.

Weather
Sunshine.
L.A. Basin: 84/61. **B6**

Markets **A10**
Opinion Voices **A12**

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